

STAGE SEVEN • HARD SKILLS

FIRSTS

GROUP VERSIONS OF KEY EXERCISES

Live, group-adapted versions of the FIRSTS that benefit most from interaction

A Citrus Edition Facilitator Resource • Companion to the FIRSTS Manual

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FIRSTS • Group Versions of Key Exercises

Stage Seven • Hard Skills

PURPOSE

Stage Seven's ninety FIRSTS are overwhelmingly written for solo, hands-on practice — build a spreadsheet, write a report, automate a task. That's the right default for a hard-skills stage; most of these genuinely need to be done individually to build real fluency. But a meaningful subset benefit from a live, social version: negotiation and delegation are inherently interpersonal, presentations need a real audience, and feedback exercises need a real second person.

This document adapts twelve FIRSTS spanning all six sections of Stage Seven into pair, small-group, or role-play formats. As with every stage, these are additions, not replacements — participants complete the individual version first, and the group version tests or deepens it. Twelve was a deliberate, conservative choice for a ninety-FIRST stage: these are specifically the exercises where a solo version alone would genuinely miss something a live, social version reveals.

Each entry includes a suggested format, the extra time it adds beyond the solo version, numbered steps you can read almost verbatim to a group, and a short note on why the live version specifically matters here.

The Twelve Adapted Exercises

FIRST K9

Survey/Questionnaire Designed — Peer Critique Swap

TIME: +15 min beyond solo drafting

1. After drafting individually, swap surveys with a partner.
2. Partner reviews for leading or double-barreled questions, marking anything ambiguous.
3. Discuss the marked items together, then revise.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Bias in your own questions is often invisible to you but obvious to a fresh reader — this is a fast, genuinely effective check.

FIRST K42

Research Presentation — Practice Circle

TIME: +20 min beyond solo prep

1. Groups of 3-4. Each person presents their research finding in under 2 minutes, leading with the actual takeaway.
2. Group gives one piece of feedback each: did the finding land in the first sentence, or did it take too long to get there?
3. Presenter revises their opening line on the spot.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This directly tests the section's core lesson — lead with the finding — in a genuinely low-stakes, fast-feedback format.

FIRST K6

Meeting Agenda Prepared — Mock Meeting Role-Play

TIME: +20 min beyond agenda drafting

1. Groups of 4-5. One person runs a short (8-minute) mock meeting using their prepared agenda; others play meeting participants.
2. Observers note whether the agenda was actually followed or abandoned once discussion started.
3. Debrief: what made it easy or hard to stick to the plan?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Preparing an agenda and actually using one under real group dynamics are genuinely different skills — this exercise tests the harder, more valuable one.

FIRST K74

Task Delegation Exercise — Paired Role-Play

TIME: +15 min beyond framing

1. Pairs. Partner A delegates a real or realistic task to Partner B, stating scope and deadline out loud.
2. Partner B asks clarifying questions as a genuinely thorough task recipient would.
3. Swap roles with a different task.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Practicing both sides of delegation, the giver and the receiver, builds genuine empathy for what makes a delegated task actually clear.

FIRST K69

Digital Presentation Feedback Received — Structured Feedback Rounds

TIME: +20 min beyond individual review

1. Small groups. Each person plays a short segment of a recorded presentation (theirs, from K34 or K51).
2. The group gives feedback using a fixed structure: one thing that worked, one thing about pacing, one thing about clarity.
3. Rotate until everyone has received feedback.

FACILITATOR NOTE

A fixed feedback structure prevents the vague, generic praise this exercise's manual entry specifically warns against.

FIRST K48

Cross-Platform Tool Integration — Troubleshooting Relay

TIME: +20 min beyond individual setup

1. Small groups, each attempting a different two-tool integration.
2. When a group gets stuck, they can “call a lifeline” to another group for a quick two-minute consult before continuing independently.
3. Groups briefly report back on what integration they built and what the lifeline call, if used, actually solved.

FACILITATOR NOTE

This mirrors how integration troubleshooting genuinely happens on real teams — mostly independent, with quick outside consults when truly stuck.

FIRST K22

Negotiation Exercise — Paired Role-Play

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. Pairs. Assign a realistic non-salary negotiation scenario (project scope, deadline extension, resource allocation).

2. Run the negotiation for 5 minutes, then swap which partner initiates.
3. Debrief as a full group: what moved the conversation toward a genuine win-win versus a stalemate?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Practicing both initiating and responding builds a more complete negotiation skill than only ever playing one role.

FIRST K24

Creative Brainstorming Session — Structured Group Brainstorm

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. Small groups. Set a specific, real prompt and a strict 5-minute judgment-free generation phase — no discussion or evaluation allowed yet.
2. Only after generation ends, spend 5 minutes as a group selecting the two strongest ideas.
3. Compare across groups: which prompt produced the most genuinely varied ideas?

FACILITATOR NOTE

Enforcing the judgment-free phase strictly is what actually produces more and better ideas — this is the single easiest rule for a facilitator to accidentally let slide.

FIRST K77

Peer Teaching Session — Teach-Back Circles

TIME: +25 min beyond prep

1. Pairs. Each person picks one hard skill from earlier in this stage they feel genuinely solid on.
2. Teach it to their partner in 5 minutes, using only their own words, no notes.
3. Partner asks one genuine clarifying question; teacher answers without looking anything up.

FACILITATOR NOTE

The clarifying question is what actually reveals a real gap in the teacher's own understanding — don't skip that step even under time pressure.

FIRST K19

Peer Review Participation — Structured Swap

TIME: +15 min beyond individual review

1. Pairs swap a real piece of work (a report, a spreadsheet, a template) from earlier in this stage.
2. Reviewer gives exactly two pieces of feedback: one specific strength, one specific, actionable improvement.
3. Swap back and discuss.

FACILITATOR NOTE

Limiting feedback to two specific points, not an open-ended list, keeps it genuinely actionable

rather than overwhelming.

FIRST K25

Cross-Functional Collaboration — Cross-Group Mixer

TIME: +20 min beyond framing

1. If your cohort has participants from different fields or functions, mix groups deliberately across those lines.
2. Assign a small joint task requiring genuine translation between each person's background (e.g., explaining a technical finding to a non-technical teammate).
3. Debrief: what vocabulary or assumption needed active translation?

FACILITATOR NOTE

If your cohort is genuinely homogeneous in background, simulate this by assigning artificial "functions" (marketing, engineering, finance) for the exercise instead.

FIRST K51

Technical Presentation to Non-Experts — Non-Expert Panel

TIME: +20 min beyond individual prep

1. If possible, invite 1–2 genuine non-experts (a friend, a facilitator from another program area) to sit as a live audience.
2. Participants present their technical work to this panel, who ask real, honest clarifying questions.
3. Panel gives direct feedback: what genuinely made sense, what didn't.

FACILITATOR NOTE

A truly non-expert audience is far more revealing than a peer audience, who often share enough background to unconsciously fill in gaps.